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Many education laws to take effect in 2026 in California

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(The Center Square) – As California looks toward 2026, here are the key education laws that will take effect.

In 2025, Gov. Gavin Newsom signed a myriad of education-related laws that will go into effect this month. One that has had much debate is Assembly Bill 495, known as the Family Preparedness Plan Act of 2025.

Authored by Assemblywoman Celeste Rodriguez, D-San Fernando, the bill claims to provide immigrant families facing deportation with solutions in taking care of their children. The legislation is designed to ensure children are not left vulnerable if a parent is unexpectedly detained by immigration officials.

Under the law, a "nonrelative extended family member" could authorize school-related medical care and enrollment in school for a minor by filling out a one-page affidavit. The parents' signature is not required and "a person who relies on this affidavit has no obligation to make any further inquiry or investigation," the affidavit states.

The California Family Council and other parental advocacy groups have been in huge opposition to the bill, arguing it creates opportunities for abuse and calling it a "child trafficker's dream."

Newsom also signed AB 727, authored by Assemblymember Mark González, D–Los Angeles, which requires the Trevor Project's LGBTQ+ suicide hotline information to be printed on the back of all public school student ID cards for grades seven through college.

The Trevor Project online platform, TrevorSpace, encourages LGBTQ+ youth ages 13 to 24 to connect and share personal stories. Yet law enforcement and family advocates have warned that the website is not monitored and can leave children vulnerable to online predators.

Brenda Lebsack, a trustee for the Santa Ana Unified School District, has testified against AB 727, stating that she was "shocked that the governor signed to have Trevor Project on the back of every ID card."

A few other education laws to highlight are AB 1264, authored by Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel, D-San Fernando Valley. This law will phase out ultra-processed foods from school meals in California.

As part of the Golden State Literacy Plan, the governor also signed AB 1454, authored by Assembly Speaker Robert Rivas, D–Salinas. The bill seeks to ensure educators and school leaders have access to training, tools and resources to improve student literacy outcomes.

SB 640, authored by Sen. Christopher Cabaldon, D-California, will grant qualifying students automatic admission to California State University campuses. Under the new law, eligible students must apply to CaliforniaColleges.edu to receive an official letter of acceptance and select the CSU campuses to which they wish to apply.

The Center Square has also reported on other California laws going into effect in 2026.

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